

Early breaks and interests

More importantly, Bizet found favor with Charles Gounod—20 years his senior—who became his lifelong friend and mentor. Inspired by one of the latter's works, Bizet produced his first major composition, *Symphony in C* (1855), now recognized as one of his finest orchestral scores. It was never performed in his lifetime, only receiving its first public airing in 1935.

In 1857, he won the Prix de Rome, which financed his studies in Italy. Here, he soon lapsed into a bohemian lifestyle and his main musical offering at that time was the comic opera *Don Procopio*. This earned him disapproval from his teachers who expected a recipient of the prestigious Prix to produce a more serious work.

“ [A] beautiful art, but ... a wretched profession.”

GEORGES BIZET, ON MUSIC, 1867

Bizet was a brilliant performer, but he refused to become a concert pianist. His interest lay in the theater. In this field, his first opera of real quality was *The Pearl Fishers*, which premiered in 1863. The public liked it, as did Berlioz, but the critics lambasted it. The show closed after 18 performances.